What Is Stoicism?

What would it mean to live well, whatever happens to you?

READING · 10 MINUTES

Stoicism 101. Give a short talk in your own words, drawing on Stoicism 101, or watch this five-minute video together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 15	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 10	Close · 15
Ground rules; names and what brought you	Your short talk or the video	The questions below	Introduce it	Agree on a regular day and time

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before tonight, what did you think “stoic” meant? What surprised you?
2. The Stoics said a good life depends on character, not circumstances. Do you believe that?
3. Think of someone you admire for how they handle hardship. What do they actually do?
4. Wisdom, courage, justice, temperance: which comes easiest to you? Which is hardest?
5. What would make a group like this worth your time each month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Evening review. Each night, ask: What went well? What didn’t? What will I do differently tomorrow?

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“What do you mean by…?” When someone says *good* or *happy*, ask them to define it first.

NOTES

What's in My Control?

Why do we spend so much energy on things we can't change?

READING · ONE PAGE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1. Some things are up to us: our judgments, intentions, and actions. Others aren't: our bodies, reputations, and other people.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	**The questions below**	Try it on a real worry	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. List what worried you this week. Which items were fully up to you?
2. Is your health in your control? Your job? Where exactly is the line?
3. If outcomes aren't up to us, why try at all?
4. What changes when you aim at your effort rather than the result?
5. Where could this idea go wrong if it's taken too far?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Mine / not mine. Once a day, split a worry into the part that's yours and the part that isn't. Act only on yours.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says something is out of their control, ask how they'd tell.

NOTES

Anger

Is it the thing that happened, or what I tell myself about it?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5: we aren't disturbed by things, but by our judgments about them. **Seneca, *On Anger* 2.4** (Book II, chapter 4): anger comes in three movements: an involuntary jolt, a judgment we agree to, and a passion we can't control. We can step in at the second.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask people to notice one moment of irritation during the week.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rewrite one judgment	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Recall a recent moment of anger. What happened, and what did you tell yourself about it?
2. Seneca says the first jolt isn't up to us, but agreeing to it is. In your example, where could you have stepped in?
3. Seneca thought anger is never useful. Do you agree?
4. What's the difference between anger and a firm, fair response?
5. What would a pause change: counting, walking away, sleeping on it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Catch the second movement. When you feel the jolt, finish the sentence "I'm telling myself that…" before you act. Then ask whether it's true.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Talk about anger stays vague until someone describes a real moment.

NOTES

Worry About the Future

Do we suffer more from what happens, or from what we imagine?

READING · TWO PAGES

Seneca, Letter 13 (“On Groundless Fears”). Many fears never arrive; Seneca asks whether a feared evil is certain before we suffer it.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Link the letter; reading it ahead is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Five quiet minutes	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What future event takes up the most room in your head right now?
2. Think of past worries. How many happened the way you feared?
3. Seneca asks whether the evil is certain. Is that comforting, or dismissive?
4. What’s the difference between planning and worrying?
5. How could calmly imagining the worst help rather than hurt?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Rehearse a setback. For five minutes, calmly picture something going wrong, and plan how you’d respond well.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“If that’s true, what follows?” Walk a worry forward, step by step, to see where it really leads.

NOTES

Difficult People

How do I stay decent toward people who make it hard?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 2.1. Each morning he expects to meet rude, ungrateful people, reminds himself they act from ignorance, and that we're made to work together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Remind people to keep examples anonymous: no names, no workplaces.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; keep it anonymous	Aloud, twice	The questions below	Write your own 2.1	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Marcus expects difficult people every morning. Is that pessimistic or practical?
2. Think of someone who frustrates you. What might they believe that makes their behavior make sense to them?
3. Does understanding someone mean excusing them?
4. In that relationship, what is actually in your control?
5. What does justice ask of you toward people you don't like?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Morning preparation. Before work, say your own version of 2.1: who you might meet today, and how you want to treat them.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" When someone says "people like that never change," invite a counterexample.

NOTES

What's Actually Good?

If money, health, and reputation aren't the goal, what is?

READING · THREE PAGES

Plato, *Euthydemus* 278e–282e. Socrates argues that wealth and health only benefit us when they're used wisely, so wisdom is what makes anything good.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Try it on a real choice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Name three things you want most. Why do you want them?
2. Can wealth or health ever harm someone? How?
3. Socrates says wisdom is what makes other things useful. Do you agree?
4. The Stoics called money and health "preferred indifferents." What's gained and lost in that view?
5. Looking back on your meetings so far, what's one idea you've actually used?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

The wise-person test. Before a decision, ask: what would a wise person do here, and why?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Bring back the control question: are the things you want most up to you?

NOTES

A Deeper Introduction

What did the Stoics actually believe, and why?

READING · ONE OR TWO SECTIONS

Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Stoicism." A little dense, but rich and readable. Too long for one meeting? Pick one or two sections.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. If you plan to read *How to Be a Stoic* next, tell members now so they can get a copy.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Choose your sentence	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea in the article surprised you most?
2. The Stoics tied ethics to their physics and logic. Does how you see the world change how you should live?
3. Which idea from our first six months does the article help explain?
4. What would you still push back on?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One sentence. Pick one sentence from the article that matters to you, and reread it each morning.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What do you mean by…?" Words like *nature* and *reason* meant something specific to the Stoics.

NOTES

The Three Disciplines

How do you practice Stoicism, not just think about it?

READING · TWO SHORT ARTICLES

Donald Robertson, "Introduction to Stoicism: The Three Disciplines" and "A Simplified Modern Approach to Stoicism." Epictetus taught through desire, action, and judgment.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with links to both articles.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Pick a daily practice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Desire, action, and judgment: which discipline do you most need right now?
2. Which practices from earlier months fit under each discipline?
3. What gets in the way of daily practice for you?
4. How could this group help you keep at it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One daily practice. Choose one practice from Robertson's simplified approach and keep it all month.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Ask for a moment this week when one of the disciplines would have helped.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part One

What does a modern Stoic life look like?

READING · FIRST HALF OF THE BOOK

Massimo Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*. Modern Stoic theory and practice, organized around Epictetus' three disciplines.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Remind members which chapters to read. Some will only get partway; that's fine.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	**The questions below**	Start the journal	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which of Pigliucci's examples comes closest to your own life?
2. Where does a modern reading change what Epictetus meant?
3. Where do you disagree with the author?
4. What would you ask him if he were here?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A one-line journal. Each evening, write one line: where did you practice Stoicism today, and where did you miss?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" Test the book's claims against members' own experience.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part Two

Which Stoic exercise is worth keeping?

READING · SECOND HALF OF THE BOOK

Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*, second half. The last chapter is a guide to basic Stoic exercises, a natural bridge into practice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask members to come ready to pick an exercise to try together next month.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	The questions below	Choose next month's exercise	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which exercise in the final chapter appeals to you most? Which least?
2. Has your view of Stoicism changed since you started? How?
3. What does the book get right about living well that we haven't discussed?
4. Which exercise should we try together next month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One exercise. Choose one exercise from the final chapter and try it daily.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" Test a favorite idea from the book against a hard case.

NOTES

A Practice Session

What happens when we practice together, not just talk?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Do the exercise together. Lead the exercise the group chose last month, such as the evening review, rehearsing a setback, or the view from above. More ideas in our practice resources.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack which exercise you'll do, so members can try it during the week.

Open · 10	Practice · 15	Discuss · 45	Plan · 10	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	The exercise, together	The questions below	How we'll keep it up	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What did you notice during the exercise?
2. Was it harder or easier than you expected? Why?
3. Which practices have you kept up this year, and which did you drop?
4. How could the group support each other's practice between meetings?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Keep it going. Continue the exercise all month, and note one thing it changed.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"If that's true, what follows?" Follow each person's observation one step further.

NOTES

Looking Back, Looking Ahead

What has a year of Stoicism changed?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Bring a passage. Each member brings one passage from the year that stayed with them and reads it aloud.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack and ask everyone to bring a passage. This is the meeting where you plan year two.

Open · 10	Share · 20	Discuss · 35	Plan · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Passages read aloud	The questions below	Choose year two's format	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea have you used most this year?
2. What still feels hard to practice?
3. What kept you coming back?
4. What should our second year look like? See Topics and Formats for options.

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A letter to yourself. As Seneca wrote to Lucilius, write a short letter to yourself to reread a year from now.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Ask what each person can keep doing, whatever the group decides.

NOTES

The Four Virtues

What does a good person actually do?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 3.6. If you find anything in life better than justice, truth, self-control, and courage, Marcus says, turn to it with all your heart. He doubts you will.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Pick tomorrow's virtue	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Think of someone you admire. Which of the four virtues do you see in them?
2. Marcus ranks virtue above everything else in life. What would you be tempted to put above it?
3. Can someone be brave without being wise? Honest without being kind?
4. Which virtue does your work or family life ask of you most?
5. Where did you practice one of them this week, even in a small way?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One virtue a day. Each morning, pick one virtue to practice. Each evening, note one moment you did.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What do you mean by…?" Ask the group to define courage or justice before debating it.

NOTES

Grief and Loss

How do we love what we know we will lose?

READING · TWO SHORT CHAPTERS

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 3 and 11. Remember that what you love is mortal. And of anything you lose, never say “I have lost it,” but “I have restored it.”

BEFORE THE MEETING

Grief can be raw. In the announcement, say the topic plainly, and at the meeting let anyone pass on personal examples.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; anyone may pass	Aloud, together	The questions below	Returned, not lost	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Epictetus says to remember that what we love is mortal. Is that comforting or cold?
2. What’s the difference between “I lost it” and “I restored it”?
3. Can a Stoic grieve? What would healthy Stoic grief look like?
4. How can we value someone fully while accepting they’re on loan?
5. If you’re willing to share: what helped you most in a past loss?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Returned, not lost. When you lose something small this month, a pen or an opportunity, practice saying “it was returned.”

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“Is that always true?” Gently test absolute claims, like “you never get over it.”

NOTES

What Others Think

Why do we care so much about opinions we don't respect?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 13: if you want to improve, be content to seem foolish.

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 12.4: we love ourselves more than anyone, yet value others' opinions of us more than our own.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and links to both passages.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	**The questions below**	Spot one choice made for show	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Whose opinion of you matters most, and why?
2. Marcus noticed we value others' opinions of us above our own. Is that true for you?
3. When is reputation worth caring about, and when isn't it?
4. What would you do differently if no one would ever know?
5. Epictetus says to be content to seem foolish. Where might that be good advice for you right now?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Reputation as an indifferent. Once a day, notice a choice made for appearances. Ask what you'd choose if no one saw.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says "everyone thinks…", ask what they actually know.

NOTES

Seneca on Saving Time

Where does your time actually go?

READING · ONE LETTER

Seneca, Letter 1 (“On Saving Time”). Most of our time is taken from us, stolen, or simply slips away. Seneca urges Lucilius to hold on to every hour. A good first letter for a group that wants to read Seneca together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Link the letter in your announcement and ask members to read it beforehand. It’s about two pages.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Plan one hour	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Seneca says time is taken, stolen, or slips away. Which is most true for you?
2. He says we are dying every day. What changes if you take that seriously?
3. Is being busy a problem, or a badge of honor?
4. What would “holding every hour” look like in your week?
5. If the group read one letter a month, what theme would you want next?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Claim an hour. Once a day, before an hour begins, decide what it’s for. Notice where it went.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“Can you give an example?” Ask for a specific hour this week that slipped away.

NOTES

Examine Your Impressions

Is it true, or does it just feel true?

READING · ONE LINE, THEN AN EXERCISE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1 (the last lines): meet every harsh impression by reminding yourself it is only an impression, not necessarily what it appears to be. Then test it. See the wiki's Examine Your Impressions.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Ask members to bring one recent moment when a first reaction turned out to be wrong.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	Test one impression together	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What impression hit you hardest this week? What was it asking you to believe?
2. When you got it wrong, was the error in the facts, the value you placed on something, or the action you took?
3. Which impressions win you over fastest: fear, pleasure, urgency, or authority?
4. Epictetus pictures a night watchman asking each impression to show its pass. What would your pass check?
5. What short question could you ask yourself in the moment?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Show me your pass. Before acting on a strong reaction, ask: What am I being asked to believe? What supports it? What can I endorse?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" It's the heart of this exercise. Use it on the group's examples.

NOTES

Accepting What Happens

What are you still arguing with?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 8: don't demand that things happen as you wish; wish them to happen as they do. **Seneca, Letter 107:** fate leads the willing and drags the unwilling. See the wiki's Accepting Reality.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Ask members to think of one thing they wish had gone differently.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Name it, release it	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What event are you still arguing with in your head?
2. Is accepting something the same as approving of it?
3. Seneca says fate leads the willing and drags the unwilling. Which have you been lately?
4. Can acceptance turn into passivity? Where's the line?
5. What became possible the last time you stopped resisting something?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Accepting reality. When an "if only" starts, name the fact plainly, notice what you're demanding, and ask what virtue requires now.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Separate what's already happened from what's still yours to choose.

NOTES